Executive Summary Report

AnalystLab Africa | Week 2 Business Analytics | Sample Superstore

Prepared 26 October 2026

The 2014–2017 Sample Superstore records show $2.30 million in sales and $286,397 in profit across 5,009 distinct orders, for a 12.47% overall profit margin. The West region and Technology category lead in both sales and profit, while Furniture has high sales but a much lower margin. Management can use the findings below to protect profitable demand and investigate low-margin regions and products.

Project Overview

This analysis reviews the selected Option 1 Superstore dataset to help retail management monitor sales, profitability, customer segments, product performance, and regional results. The supplied CSV contains 9,994 transaction-line records covering 2014 through 2017. Measures are calculated from the original row-level data: sales and profit are summed, orders are distinct Order IDs, Average Sales is total sales divided by distinct orders, and Profit Margin is total profit divided by total sales.

The supplied Power BI export was also reviewed. It contains the requested KPI cards and most required visuals; its State map is currently disabled by a Power BI security setting. The business results in this report are calculated directly from the CSV and do not rely on the disabled map.

Performance Snapshot

Measure	Verified result
Total sales	$2,297,200.86
Total profit	$286,397.02
Distinct orders	5,009
Average sales per order	$458.61
Profit margin	12.47%

Part 4 Business Insights

1. Regional performance is led by the West, while Central has the weakest margin.

West generated $725,458 in sales (31.6% of total) and $108,418 in profit, the highest among the four regions. Central recorded $501,240 in sales but only $39,706 in profit, a 7.9% margin; South had the lowest sales at $391,722 but higher profit than Central at $46,749.

2. Technology leads category sales and profit; Furniture converts sales to profit less effectively.

Technology produced $836,154 in sales and $145,455 in profit, a 17.4% margin. Furniture sales were $742,000, close to Office Supplies at $719,047, but Furniture profit was only $18,451 (2.5% margin), compared with $122,491 for Office Supplies (17.0% margin).

3. Profit varies sharply by product line, with Tables the largest sub-category loss.

Copiers generated $55,618 profit, followed by Phones at $44,516 and Accessories at $41,937. Tables lost $17,725, Bookcases lost $3,473, and Supplies lost $1,189. At product level, the Canon imageCLASS 2200 Advanced Copier was the most profitable individual product in the file at $25,200.

4. Consumer customers provide the largest revenue base, while Home Office has the highest segment margin.

Consumer contributed $1,161,401 in sales (50.6% of total) and $134,119 in profit. Home Office generated $429,653 in sales and $60,299 in profit, for a 14.0% margin, compared with 11.6% for Consumer and 13.0% for Corporate.

5. Annual sales and profit recovered after a small 2015 sales decline and rose through 2017.

Sales were $484,247 in 2014 and $470,533 in 2015 (down 2.8% year over year), then increased to $609,206 in 2016 (+29.5%) and $733,215 in 2017 (+20.4%). Sales in 2017 were 51.4% higher than in 2014. Profit also rose each year from $49,544 in 2014 to $93,439 in 2017.

Business Risks

- **Low-margin Furniture exposure.** Furniture contributes nearly one-third of sales but has a 2.5% margin; a small deterioration in price or cost could erode its modest profit.
- **Loss-making product lines.** Tables, Bookcases, and Supplies are negative-profit sub-categories in the observed period; continuing to grow their sales without correcting unit economics could increase losses.
- **Uneven regional profitability.** Central's 7.9% margin is below the overall 12.5% margin, so regional sales growth there may not translate into comparable profit unless management understands its product mix, discounts, and costs.

Business Opportunities

- **Scale high-margin categories.** Technology and Office Supplies together account for most recorded profit and each deliver margins near 17%.
- **Grow profitable Home Office demand.** Home Office is smaller by revenue than Consumer but has the highest segment margin in the data.
- **Expand winning products selectively.** Copiers, Phones, and Accessories are the leading profit sub-categories; test bundles and cross-sell offers while monitoring contribution margin.

Part 5 Business Recommendations

1. Investigate Central region margin before increasing regional spend.

Action. Review Central transactions by product, discount, and shipping mode; compare the mix with West and East. Set a margin improvement target and monitor profit as well as sales. This could improve the quality of regional growth.

Linked insight: Insight 1.

2. Prioritize profitable category growth and reset Furniture pricing.

Action. Maintain availability and test demand campaigns for Technology and Office Supplies. Review Furniture assortment, supplier costs, and discount thresholds; use minimum margin rules before promotions. This could raise profit without relying only on higher revenue.

Linked insight: Insight 2.

3. Run a product-level recovery plan for loss-making sub-categories.

Action. For Tables, Bookcases, and Supplies, review item costs, return/fulfillment economics where available, pricing, and promotions. Reprice or renegotiate selected items and pause campaigns that remain below an agreed contribution threshold. Expand profitable Copier, Phone, and Accessory offers through measured pilots. This could reduce avoidable losses and concentrate activity on proven contributors.

Linked insight: Insight 3.

4. Use different growth tests for Consumer and Home Office.

Action. Protect the Consumer base with relevant bundles and retention offers, measuring incremental profit rather than order volume alone. Pilot targeted Home Office campaigns because its observed margin is highest, and scale only if the test adds profitable sales. This could balance revenue scale with margin quality.

Linked insight: Insight 4.

5. Plan inventory and staffing against the rising sales trend, with regular forecast checks.

Action. Use the 2016–2017 growth as a planning signal, but build monthly forecasts and compare actuals with plan before committing inventory or capacity. Include a slower-growth scenario because 2015 sales declined. This could reduce stockouts during demand growth and limit overstock if growth eases.

Linked insight: Insight 5.

Conclusion

The dataset shows a healthy overall profit, rising annual sales after 2015, and clear areas where the sales mix and profit do not move together. Management should protect Technology and Office Supplies performance, investigate Furniture and loss-making product lines, and focus regional improvement work on Central. Testing each action against both sales and profit will help the company grow while preserving margin.

Calculation Notes

All amounts are USD and are rounded to the nearest dollar in the narrative. Percentages use row-level sums from the supplied Sample Superstore CSV. Sales share is group sales divided by total sales; margin is group profit divided by group sales; annual change compares each year's sales with the previous calendar year. Average Sales is average sales per distinct order, not average sales per transaction row. Findings are descriptive for the 2014–2017 sample and do not establish causes or forecast future performance.